



Precision training: Athletes can train hard, train consistently, and still be poorly prepared for the specific demands of their sport and skills. Why? Because simply doing work is not the same as doing the right work for the specific demands.

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When people hear ‘underprepared’, many imagine individuals who do not train at all — sitting on the couch, overeating, and then suddenly asking their bodies to sprint, jump, and run. Yes, that is one form of under-preparedness.

But it is not the most common scenario, even when robust recovery protocols are in place. Athletes can train hard, train consistently, and still be poorly prepared for the specific demands of their sport and skills. Why? Because simply doing work is not the same as doing the right work for the specific demands.

An athlete can be busy and still be completely undercooked.

The misallocation-mismatch problem

Under-preparedness is often not a lack of effort, but a lack of appropriate distribution and specialisation. It is about working smart, not merely ticking boxes or accumulating time. Hard work without direction is futile.

Progress must align with the immediate needs of the athlete. When there is a mismatch across training blocks relative to the sport, skill, and individual requirements, under-preparedness is inevitable. This is not rocket science for professionals. Too often, however, laziness is mistaken for under-preparedness.

The real injury equation

A real injury in a non-contact sport occurs when demand exceeds the capacity of the muscles and tissues at that specific moment in time and space. Put simply: demand is greater than supply.

When a demand is too rapid or too high, it becomes overload — because the body’s capacity to respond has not been built. Often, the issue is not that the workload is excessive, but that the work capacity has not been designed specifically to absorb the load, leaving the athlete undercooked.

Under-preparedness is a supply problem

If overload is a volume issue, under-preparedness is a supply issue. Preparedness is not built by training everything equally; it is built by training the right things in the right ratio, aligned to demand and supply.

Preparation becomes intentional, not accidental. It is strategic and calibrated over months, weeks, and days, with multiple data inputs stitched together to peak at the right time with sufficient robustness for the demands. When stressors are not attuned properly, the issue is under-preparedness rather than excessive overload.

Preparedness is built, not assumed

The takeaway is simple: preparedness must be constructed, not conjectured, wished into existence, or assumed. Keeping athletes healthy and robust depends on designing the right mix of training and exposure.

Underprepared athletes do not break down because they are weak, but because they are mismatched. And mismatches are avoidable with a methodical approach.

Peak performance and durability do not happen by accident; they emerge from the precise distribution of demands tailored to the individual athlete.